

Why Nobody's Asleep Yet

Seven bedtime problems, for kids and grown-ups: why it happens, and the one thing that helps.

Your child won't sleep? Page 2 →

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Part 1

Your child won't sleep



Three bedtime problems. The real why. One thing to try tonight.

"Comes and finds me around 1200 every night."

Why

For the first few hours, a child's sleep is very deep. In one study, 78% of children slept through a smoke alarm.

Then sleep gets lighter and he half-wakes, like we all do.

You're not where he left you. So he comes to find you.

No blame if you stay. A Montreal study suggests parents often stay because the nights were already hard.

Source: Bruck and Thomas, Victoria University, Melbourne, in Fire and Materials (reported 2011). Thiedke, 2001, review, South Carolina. Kang and Kim, 2021, review, South Korea. Simard and colleagues, 2008, Université de Montréal.

Tonight

Reviews of the research agree: what's there when a child drops off is what he looks for when he wakes up alone.

So at lights out, look at what's there as he drops off: you, the light, the music. Keep only what can still be there in the middle of the night.

"he's yawning his head off but is fighting it so hard."

Why

In the few hours before the body's usual sleep time, the body clock pushes hardest to stay awake.

Researchers call it the "forbidden zone for sleep".

So he's shattered, and he still can't drop off. That's the second wind. Not cheek.

Source: Monterastelli and colleagues, 2024, Rush University, Chicago, Frontiers in Sleep. Hartstein and colleagues, 2022, University of Colorado Boulder.

Tonight

In a Colorado study of young children, an hour of light much dimmer than a normal room cut most of the signal that tells the body it's night.

So for the last hour before bed, switch the big light off and keep the room as dim as you can.

"She generally always kicks the covers off when she's in bed"

Why

To drop off, the body has to let heat out.

In children, much of it seems to leave through the back and tummy.

In a small Japanese study, about 70% of the children slept with no cover at all. It may be how she cools down to sleep.

Source: Okamoto-Mizuno, Mizuno and Shirakawa, 2018, Tohoku Fukushi University, Japan. Bach and colleagues, 2020, Université de Picardie Jules Verne.

Tonight

When you look in on her and the duvet's on the floor: if she's asleep, leave it there.

Your child's checklist

- [ ] Comes to find you in the night. At lights out, look at what's there as he drops off. Keep only what can still be there in the middle of the night.
- [ ] Yawning but fighting it. Last hour before bed: big light off, room as dim as you can.
- [ ] Kicks the covers off. Duvet on the floor and she's asleep? Leave it there.

End of Part 1



That's the kids' part done. Pick one for tonight.

Can't sleep yourself? Page 8 →

Part 2

You can't sleep



Four grown-up problems. The real why. One thing to try tonight.

"around 3am wake and its as if all the lights go on"

Why

Your deepest sleep comes in the first few hours. After that it's lighter, so it takes less to wake you.

And your body clock puts your mood at its lowest between 1 and 4am.

Same worry. Different hour.

Source: Bes and colleagues, 1991, University of Amsterdam, in Sleep. Tubbs and colleagues, 2022, University of Arizona. Jansson-Fröjmark and colleagues, 2024, Karolinska Institutet, Journal of Sleep Research.

Tonight

A 2024 review of 11 studies looked at one set of habits: bed is for sleeping, and if you're not sleeping, you get up. It beat doing nothing, for dropping off and for total sleep.

So if you're wide awake at 3am: get up, keep the light low, and go back to bed when you feel sleepy.

"my thoughts going round and round my head like squirrels in a cage"

Why

Scientists in Glasgow recorded people saying their thoughts out loud while they tried to drop off.

The longest waits went with two kinds of thought: sorting out problems, and thinking about sleep itself.

Your head isn't being silly. It's still at work.

Source: Wicklow and Espie, 2000, University of Glasgow. Scullin and colleagues, 2018, Baylor University, Journal of Experimental Psychology: General.

Tonight

In a Baylor study, people who wrote a to-do list before bed dropped off faster than people who wrote what they'd already done. The more specific the list, the faster.

So five minutes before bed, write your to-do list for the days ahead. Be specific.

"No matter how hard I try I just can't fall asleep."

Why

Falling asleep is automatic. Effort gets in its way.

In a Virginia study, people with a busy head were told to fall asleep as fast as they could. They took longer than people who weren't trying at all.

Watching the clock is trying, with numbers. In a London experiment, people asked to watch a clock while trying to sleep worried more and took longer to drop off. Even the good sleepers.

So the more you try, and the more you check, the more awake you stay.

Source: Ansfield, Wegner and Bowser, 1996, University of Virginia. Espie, Broomfield and colleagues, 2006, University of Glasgow. Tang, Schmidt and Harvey, 2007, King's College London.

Tonight

Before you get into bed, turn the clock to the wall. Put your phone face down, out of reach. It's a clock too.

"scrolling on my phone keeps me company but also keeps me awake"

Why

Dutch researchers found that people who had resisted more temptations during the day were more likely to put off going to bed.

After a day of holding it all together, the tank is empty. That's not weakness.

Source: Kamphorst and colleagues, 2018, Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam and Utrecht University. Chang and colleagues, 2015, Harvard, in PNAS.

Tonight

In a Harvard study, people reading on a light-up e-reader took longer to fall asleep, and felt less sleepy in the evening, than with a printed book. (An e-reader, not a phone.)

So take a paper book to bed instead of the lit screen.

Your checklist

- [ ] Wide awake at 3am. Get up, keep the light low, go back to bed when you feel sleepy.
- [ ] Thoughts going round. Five minutes before bed, write your to-do list for the days ahead.
- [ ] Trying too hard. Turn the clock to the wall, phone face down, out of reach.
- [ ] Scrolling to switch off. Take a paper book to bed instead of the lit screen.

The end



That's your part done. Pick one for tonight.

Sleep well. Or at least, sleep.

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